

JSS 3 CHRISTIAN RELIGIOUS STUDIES LESSON NOTES

FIRST TERM

Week	Topic	Content
1	The Promise of the Holy Spirit (Part 1)	John 14:16-17, 26; John 16:5-16 – Jesus promises the coming of the Holy Spirit; Acts 1:3-5 – waiting for the promise.
2	The Coming of the Holy Spirit	Acts 2:1-13 – The Day of Pentecost, speaking in tongues, reactions of the people.
3	Peter's First Speech and its Effects	Acts 2:14-41 – Peter's boldness, message of repentance, conversion of about 3,000 souls.
4	Fellowship in the Early Church (Part 1)	Acts 2:41-47 – Unity, sharing, prayers, breaking of bread.
5	Midterm Examination	—
6	Fellowship in the Early Church (Part 2)	Acts 5:1-11 – Fraud in the church (Ananias and Sapphira). Acts 6:1-2 – Murmuring and complaints.
7	Midterm Break	—
8	Selection of Deacons	Acts 6:1-7 – Appointment of Stephen and six others; responsibilities of deacons.
9	Persecution of Early Believers (Part 1)	Acts 3:1-11, 4:1-22 – Arrest of Peter and John; Acts 6:8-15, 7:1-60 – Arrest and martyrdom of Stephen.
10	Persecution of Early Believers (Part 2)	Acts 8:1-3; 9:1-2 – Saul's persecution; Acts 12:1-4 – Martyrdom of James.
11	Revision	All topics from Weeks 1–10.
12	Examination	—
13	Closing	—

WEEK 1: THE PROMISE OF THE HOLY SPIRIT (PART 1)

This lesson explores the **promise of the Holy Spirit**, a central theme in the New Testament, emphasizing God's provision of guidance, comfort, and empowerment to believers. The Holy Spirit is the **third person of the Trinity**, co-equal with the Father and the Son, and plays a vital role in the life of Christians by **teaching, guiding, comforting, convicting, and empowering them for service**.



JESUS PROMISES THE COMING OF THE HOLY SPIRIT (John 14:16-17, 26; John 16:5-16):

- Jesus reassured His disciples that even though He would **leave them physically**, He would **send the Holy Spirit** to remain with them forever.
- The Holy Spirit is referred to as the **Comforter, Advocate, Teacher, and Helper**. The roles include:

- **Teacher:** Guides believers into all truth and reveals the meaning of Jesus' teachings.
- **Reminder:** Reminds believers of everything Jesus taught.
- **Convictor:** Convicts the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment.
- **Empowerer:** Gives courage, wisdom, and strength to fulfill God's mission.
- Jesus highlighted that the Holy Spirit's coming was **essential for continuing His ministry** on earth through the disciples.

Key points:

- The promise of the Holy Spirit was made **before Jesus' crucifixion**, showing God's forethought and plan for the disciples.
- Believers are not left **directionless or powerless**; the Holy Spirit equips them to live godly lives.
- This promise assures Christians of **God's continuous presence, guidance, and protection**.

WAITING FOR THE PROMISE (Acts 1:3-5):

- After His resurrection, Jesus spent **forty days teaching His disciples** about the kingdom of God and preparing them for their mission.
- He instructed them to **stay in Jerusalem and wait for the promise of the Father**, which is the baptism of the Holy Spirit.
- Waiting signifies:
 - **Patience:** Learning to trust God's timing rather than rushing ahead.
 - **Obedience:** Following Jesus' instruction demonstrates faithfulness.
 - **Preparation:** Spiritual readiness is required to receive empowerment from the Holy Spirit.

- The promise was fulfilled on **Pentecost (Acts 2:1-4)** when the Holy Spirit descended, enabling the disciples to speak in different tongues and boldly preach the gospel.

Key points:

- The period of waiting highlights the importance of **faith, discipline, and spiritual readiness**.
- The coming of the Holy Spirit marked the **beginning of the Christian mission** to the world.
- Believers today are also called to **wait on God through prayer, devotion, and obedience** to receive His guidance and empowerment.

LESSON APPLICATION:

- Students are encouraged to **trust God's promises**, just as the disciples did.
- Understanding the role of the Holy Spirit helps believers to:
 - **Grow spiritually** by developing a personal relationship with God.
 - Make **wise decisions** in line with God's will.
 - **Serve effectively** in the church, community, and society.
 - **Experience comfort, guidance, and conviction** in daily life.
- The lesson teaches the importance of **faithful waiting, prayer, and spiritual readiness** for God's empowerment.

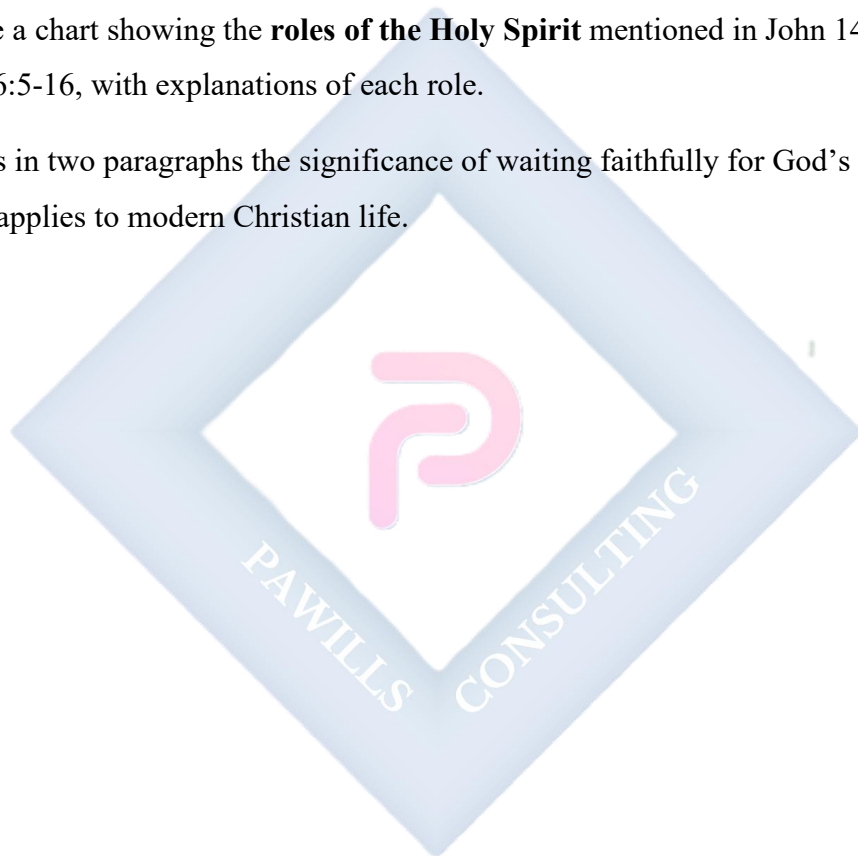
EVALUATION:

1. Explain in your own words the promise of the Holy Spirit.
2. List four roles of the Holy Spirit as described in John 14:16-17, 26 and John 16:5-16.
3. Describe the instructions Jesus gave His disciples regarding waiting for the promise.

4. Why is waiting for God's promises important in the life of a believer?
5. How did the coming of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost empower the disciples?

ASSIGNMENT:

1. Write a detailed essay (250 words) on how the Holy Spirit empowers Christians for service and guidance.
2. Prepare a chart showing the **roles of the Holy Spirit** mentioned in John 14:16-26 and John 16:5-16, with explanations of each role.
3. Discuss in two paragraphs the significance of waiting faithfully for God's promises and how it applies to modern Christian life.



WEEK 2: THE COMING OF THE HOLY SPIRIT

Acts 2:1–13 – The Day of Pentecost, Speaking in Tongues, Reactions of the People



INTRODUCTION

- The coming of the Holy Spirit is a **major turning point** in the history of Christianity.
- It fulfilled the promises of Jesus to His disciples before His ascension (John 14:16–17; Acts 1:8).
- Pentecost was originally a **Jewish harvest festival** celebrated 50 days after the Passover. In Hebrew it was called *Shavuot*, the Feast of Weeks, commemorating both harvest and the giving of the Law on Mount Sinai.

- On this day, the disciples, who had been waiting and praying in Jerusalem, received the Holy Spirit.
- This event marked the beginning of the disciples' public ministry and the official **birth of the Church**.

THE DAY OF PENTECOST (ACTS 2:1–4)

- The disciples were gathered together in the upper room, in **unity and prayer**, as Jesus had commanded them.
- Suddenly, unusual supernatural events occurred:
 - A **sound from heaven** like a mighty rushing wind filled the entire house. Wind symbolizes the invisible, life-giving breath of God.
 - **Tongues as of fire** appeared and rested on each disciple. Fire represents purification, power, and the presence of God.
 - Each disciple was **filled with the Holy Spirit**.
 - They began to speak in **different tongues (languages)** as the Spirit enabled them.
- This was not a natural occurrence but a divine empowerment, showing that God had poured His Spirit upon them.

SPEAKING IN TONGUES (ACTS 2:5–11)

- Jerusalem was crowded with **devout Jews and proselytes** from many nations because of the Pentecost festival.
- They were amazed to hear the apostles speaking in their own native languages, even though the apostles were Galileans with little education.
- The disciples spoke of the **wonderful works of God**, glorifying Him in many tongues.
- The nations and regions represented included:

1. Parthia
 2. Media
 3. Elam
 4. Mesopotamia
 5. Cappadocia
 6. Pontus
 7. Asia Minor
 8. Phrygia
 9. Pamphylia
 10. Egypt
 11. Libya (near Cyrene)
 12. Visitors from Rome
 13. Crete
 14. Arabia
- This shows the **universal nature of the gospel** – Christianity was not only for Jews but for the whole world.

REACTIONS OF THE PEOPLE (ACTS 2:12–13)

- The event caused mixed reactions among the people present:
 1. **Amazement and Awe** – Many were astonished that they could hear their own languages being spoken fluently. They marveled at the power of God.
 2. **Confusion and Perplexity** – Some did not understand the meaning and asked questions like: *“What does this mean?”*

3. **Mockery and Ridicule** – Others mocked the apostles, accusing them of being drunk with new wine. They dismissed the miracle as foolishness.
- These reactions show that not everyone accepts the works of God in the same way. While some believe and are inspired, others doubt and criticize.

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE COMING OF THE HOLY SPIRIT

1. **Fulfillment of Prophecy** – It fulfilled Joel 2:28–29 about God pouring His Spirit upon all flesh.
2. **Fulfillment of Jesus' Promise** – Jesus had assured His disciples they would receive the Comforter (John 14:16–17; Acts 1:8).
3. **Birth of the Christian Church** – Pentecost is regarded as the day the Christian Church officially began.
4. **Empowerment for Evangelism** – The disciples received boldness, courage, and supernatural ability to preach the gospel.
5. **Universality of the Gospel** – Speaking in many languages showed that the gospel was for all nations, not for Jews alone.
6. **Unity of Believers** – The event demonstrated the importance of praying and waiting together in one accord.
7. **Presence of God's Spirit** – The wind, fire, and tongues symbolized God's living presence among His people.
8. **Foundation for Missionary Work** – The miracle prepared the way for rapid expansion of Christianity across nations.

LESSONS FOR CHRISTIANS TODAY

- Christians must learn to **wait on God in prayer** for His power and guidance.

- The Holy Spirit is essential for living a holy and bold Christian life.
- Believers must be **open to the Spirit's gifts**, which enable effective service in God's kingdom.
- Christianity is a **universal faith** – it cuts across tribes, races, and languages.
- Just like in Pentecost, Christians may face **mockery and opposition**, but they must remain steadfast.
- The Church grows when believers are united in faith and obedience.

EVALUATION

1. Explain what happened to the disciples on the Day of Pentecost.
2. Mention and explain the two major symbols that appeared when the Holy Spirit came.
3. List at least five nations whose people were present in Jerusalem during Pentecost.
4. State three reactions of the people to the event of Pentecost.
5. Why is the Day of Pentecost regarded as the “birthday of the Church”?

ASSIGNMENT

1. Describe in detail the supernatural signs that accompanied the coming of the Holy Spirit.
2. State and explain four significance of the coming of the Holy Spirit to the early Church.
3. Write short notes on the following:
 - a. The rushing wind
 - b. Tongues of fire
 - c. Speaking in tongues
 - d. The accusation of drunkenness

WEEK 3: PETER'S FIRST SPEECH AND ITS EFFECTS

Acts 2:14–41 – Peter's Boldness, Message of Repentance, Conversion of about 3,000 Souls



INTRODUCTION

- After the resurrection and ascension of Jesus Christ, the disciples received the Holy Spirit on the Day of Pentecost (Acts 2:1–13).
- This extraordinary event drew a large crowd in Jerusalem, many of whom were confused, amazed, or mocking the disciples.
- Peter, filled with the Holy Spirit, stood up and delivered a bold speech explaining the meaning of the event, pointing to the prophecy of Joel, and preaching Jesus Christ as the risen Messiah.

PETER'S BOLDNESS

- Peter had previously denied Jesus three times out of fear, but after receiving the Holy Spirit, he became courageous and fearless.
- He boldly addressed the multitude of Jews in Jerusalem without shame or hesitation.
- He clarified that the disciples were not drunk as some accused, but rather filled with the Holy Spirit as prophesied by Joel (Joel 2:28–32).
- His boldness shows the transforming power of the Holy Spirit in the life of a believer.

MESSAGE OF REPENTANCE

- Peter preached that Jesus of Nazareth was approved by God through mighty works, wonders, and signs.
- He told the people that they crucified Jesus, but God raised Him from the dead.
- He declared that Jesus' resurrection was in fulfillment of the Old Testament prophecy (Psalm 16:8–11).
- Peter explained that Jesus had been exalted at the right hand of God and had poured out the Holy Spirit.
- He concluded by affirming that God made Jesus both Lord and Christ, whom they crucified.
- On hearing this, the people were “cut to the heart” and asked, “Brothers, what shall we do?”
- Peter told them to **repent and be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of sins**, and they would receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.

CONVERSION OF ABOUT 3,000 SOULS

- After Peter's speech, many accepted his message wholeheartedly.
- About **3,000 souls were baptized and added to the Church that very day.**
- This marked the beginning of rapid Church growth and the spread of Christianity.
- The new believers devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching, fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayers (Acts 2:42).
- The conversion demonstrated the power of the gospel message and the work of the Holy Spirit in convicting people of sin.

LESSONS FROM PETER'S SPEECH

- The Holy Spirit empowers believers with boldness and courage.
- Repentance and faith in Jesus Christ bring forgiveness of sins and salvation.
- God's promises in Scripture are always fulfilled.
- Preaching the true gospel brings transformation and church growth.
- Every Christian has the responsibility to share the message of repentance and salvation.

EVALUATION

1. Explain how Peter showed boldness in his first speech.
2. What was the central message of Peter's sermon in Acts 2:14–41?
3. State three effects of Peter's speech on the people who heard him.
4. Why is repentance important in the Christian faith?
5. Mention three lessons Christians can learn from the conversion of 3,000 souls.

ASSIGNMENT

1. Write in detail the role of the Holy Spirit in Peter's boldness and the success of his first sermon.
2. Compare Peter's behavior before and after Pentecost, showing the change in his character.
3. Explain how the message of Peter's speech is still relevant to Christians today.



WEEK 4: FELLOWSHIP IN THE EARLY CHURCH (PART 1)

Acts 2:41-47 – Unity, Sharing, Prayers, Breaking of Bread



INTRODUCTION TO FELLOWSHIP

- **Fellowship** in the Christian context refers to the close relationship, association, and communion among believers.
- It emphasizes unity, mutual support, spiritual growth, and collective worship.
- The early church in Jerusalem, as described in Acts 2:41-47, provides a model for Christian fellowship.

FEATURES OF FELLOWSHIP IN THE EARLY CHURCH

1. UNITY

- Believers were united in **faith, purpose, and worship**.
- Unity involved sharing common beliefs, goals, and commitment to God's teachings.
- Acts 2:44: "All that believed were together and had all things in common."
- **Significance:** Unity strengthened the church, promoted peace, and enhanced cooperation among members.

2. SHARING

- Members shared **resources, possessions, and support** with one another.
- Sharing included food, wealth, and material needs to help the poor and less privileged.
- Acts 2:45: "They sold their possessions and goods and distributed the proceeds to all, as any had need."
- **Significance:** Sharing fostered love, reduced inequality, and reflected Christ-like generosity.

3. PRAYERS

- Prayer was central to the fellowship of the early church.
- Believers **prayed together**, sought guidance, and interceded for one another.
- Acts 2:42: "They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer."
- **Significance:** Prayer strengthened faith, unity, and dependence on God.

4. BREAKING OF BREAD

- Refers to **communal meals and the Lord's Supper (Eucharist)**.
- It was a symbol of **remembrance, gratitude, and spiritual communion** with Christ.
- Acts 2:42: Members met "for the breaking of bread" regularly.

- **Significance:** Reinforced spiritual unity, shared faith experience, and mutual encouragement.

IMPORTANCE OF FELLOWSHIP IN THE CHURCH

1. **Spiritual Growth:** Fellowship nurtures faith, understanding, and discipleship.
2. **Mutual Support:** Helps members in times of need through material, emotional, or spiritual support.
3. **Promotes Unity and Harmony:** Reduces conflicts and fosters peace among believers.
4. **Strengthens Evangelism:** United Christians attract others to the faith through love and example.
5. **Encourages Regular Worship and Prayer:** Collective worship deepens devotion and dependence on God.
6. **Reflects Christ's Teachings:** Fellowship demonstrates obedience to Jesus' command to love one another (John 13:34-35).

EVALUATION

1. Define fellowship in the context of the early church.
2. List four features of fellowship in Acts 2:41-47.
3. Explain the importance of unity among believers.
4. Why was sharing significant in the early church?
5. How did prayers and breaking of bread strengthen the fellowship?

ASSIGNMENT

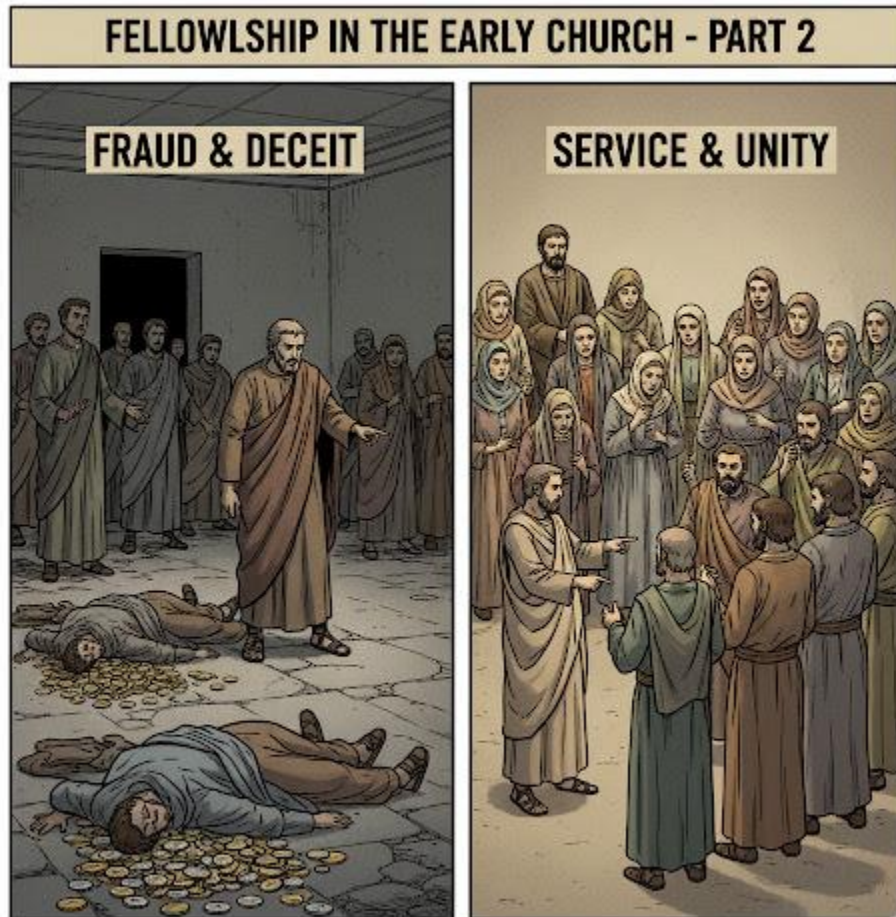
1. Write an essay: "Lessons Modern Churches Can Learn from Fellowship in the Early Church."

2. Conduct an interview with a church member and identify **three ways your local church practices fellowship today.**
3. List five ways Christians can maintain unity and sharing in their fellowship groups.



WEEK 6: FELLOWSHIP IN THE EARLY CHURCH (PART 2)

Acts 5:1–11 – Fraud in the Church (Ananias and Sapphira); Acts 6:1–2 – Murmuring and Complaints



FRAUD IN THE CHURCH (ANANIAS AND SAPPHIRA) – ACTS 5:1–11

The early Christians lived in fellowship, sharing their belongings and selling their possessions to help one another. Everyone contributed honestly and willingly. However, a couple named **Ananias and Sapphira** decided to act dishonestly.

Ananias sold a piece of land and, with the knowledge of his wife Sapphira, kept back part of the money for themselves. He brought only a portion to the apostles but pretended that he had brought all the proceeds.

Peter, filled with the Holy Spirit, confronted Ananias and asked him why he had allowed Satan to fill his heart to lie to the Holy Spirit. Peter reminded him that the land was his before selling it, and even after the sale, the money was his to do with as he wished. But his deceit was not against men but against God. Upon hearing this, **Ananias fell down and died instantly.**

Later, Sapphira came in without knowing what had happened. She too was questioned by Peter, and she repeated the same lie. She also fell down and died. Great fear fell upon the entire church and all who heard the story.

Lessons from Ananias and Sapphira's fraud:

1. God hates dishonesty and hypocrisy.
2. Fraud and deceit in the church bring judgment.
3. The Holy Spirit cannot be deceived.
4. Christians must give sincerely and not for show or recognition.
5. The fear of God must be upheld in the church.

MURMURING AND COMPLAINTS – ACTS 6:1–2

As the number of disciples grew in Jerusalem, a problem arose in the church. The Greek-speaking Jews (Hellenists) complained against the Hebrew-speaking Jews because their widows were being neglected in the daily distribution of food.

This murmuring brought division and dissatisfaction among the believers. To solve this problem, the twelve apostles called the disciples together. They explained that it was not proper for them to abandon preaching the word of God in order to serve tables. They instructed the church to select seven men of good reputation, filled with the Spirit and wisdom, to oversee the daily distribution.

This led to the appointment of seven deacons, including Stephen, Philip, Prochorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas, and Nicolas. The apostles then devoted themselves fully to prayer and the ministry of the word.

Lessons from murmuring and complaints:

1. Growth in the church may bring challenges, but they must be solved with wisdom.
2. Complaints should be handled fairly and justly.
3. Leaders must not neglect the spiritual work of prayer and teaching.
4. Delegation of responsibilities is necessary in the church.
5. The appointment of deacons shows the importance of service in God's house.

SUMMARY

- In Acts 5:1–11, Ananias and Sapphira were punished for lying and committing fraud in the early church. Their hypocrisy brought death and fear among believers.
- In Acts 6:1–2, murmuring arose between the Hellenists and Hebrews over the neglect of widows. The apostles resolved the matter by delegating duties to seven deacons, allowing them to focus on prayer and preaching.
- These stories teach the importance of honesty, unity, service, and proper leadership in the church.

EVALUATION

1. Narrate the story of Ananias and Sapphira.
2. What lesson should Christians learn from their punishment?
3. Explain the cause of murmuring in Acts 6:1–2.
4. How did the apostles solve the problem of neglect in food distribution?
5. Mention three lessons Christians can learn from the appointment of deacons.

ASSIGNMENT

1. Write in detail how the sin of Ananias and Sapphira was exposed and the consequence they faced.
2. Identify four qualities required in those chosen to serve in the early church.
3. Discuss two dangers of murmuring and complaints in the church today.



WEEK 8: SELECTION OF DEACONS

The selection of deacons in the early church is a **biblical example of organized church leadership**. It highlights the importance of service, fairness, and effective administration in church growth. This lesson examines **Acts 6:1-7**, the appointment of Stephen and six others, and the **responsibilities of deacons** in the church.



BIBLICAL ACCOUNT (ACTS 6:1-7):

- In the early church, as the number of believers grew, **a problem arose**: Greek-speaking widows were being neglected in daily food distribution.

- The apostles recognized the issue and **appointed seven men of good reputation, full of the Spirit and wisdom**, to take charge of the distribution of food and welfare of the community.
- **The men appointed were:** Stephen, Philip, Prochorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas, and Nicolas.
- This decision **ensured fairness, allowed apostles to focus on prayer and ministry of the Word**, and demonstrated organizational skills within the church.

SELECTION CRITERIA FOR DEACONS:

- **Good reputation:** Must be trustworthy and respected by the church community.
- **Full of the Holy Spirit:** Spiritually mature, with integrity and faithfulness.
- **Wisdom:** Able to make fair and just decisions in church administration.
- **Commitment to service:** Willing to serve selflessly and diligently.

RESPONSIBILITIES OF DEACONS:

- **Distribution of resources:** Ensure fair distribution of food, aid, and other church materials.
- **Assistance in church administration:** Support pastors and elders in organizing church programs.
- **Spiritual guidance:** Help maintain discipline and moral standards among members.
- **Pastoral support:** Assist in visiting, caring for the sick, elderly, widows, and vulnerable members.
- **Promoting unity:** Resolve disputes and ensure harmonious relationships within the congregation.
- **Prayer and service:** Participate actively in spiritual and community activities.

LESSONS FROM THE SELECTION OF DEACONS:

- **Leadership is service:** True leaders prioritize the needs of others.
- **Delegation is important:** Distributing responsibilities ensures efficiency and prevents neglect.
- **Spiritual maturity matters:** Leaders should be spiritually equipped to serve faithfully.
- **Fairness and integrity are essential:** Maintaining justice strengthens trust and unity in the church.

EVALUATION:

1. Explain why the apostles appointed deacons in the early church.
2. List the qualities required for selecting deacons.
3. Describe four responsibilities of deacons in the church.
4. How does the selection of deacons promote unity and fairness in the church?

ASSIGNMENT:

1. Write an essay (200–250 words) on the importance of deacons in the modern church.
2. Prepare a table showing the **names of the first deacons and their responsibilities** according to Acts 6:1-7.
3. Role-play a scenario where deacons are resolving a problem in the church and explain the steps taken.

WEEK 9: PERSECUTION OF EARLY BELIEVERS (PART 1)

Acts 3:1–11, 4:1–22 – Arrest of Peter and John; Acts 6:8–15, 7:1–60 – Arrest and Martyrdom of Stephen



ARREST OF PETER AND JOHN (Acts 3:1–11, 4:1–22)

1. Healing of the Lame Man (Acts 3:1–11):

- Peter and John went to the temple at the hour of prayer.
- At the Beautiful Gate, they met a lame man who begged for alms.

- Peter declared, *“Silver and gold I have none, but in the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk.”*
- The man was instantly healed, leaping and praising God.
- This miracle drew a large crowd, leading to Peter’s sermon about Jesus.

2. The Arrest (Acts 4:1–22):

- The priests, the captain of the temple, and the Sadducees were angry because Peter and John preached about Jesus and the resurrection.
- They arrested them and kept them in custody until the next day.
- When brought before the council, Peter boldly declared that the lame man was healed by the power of Jesus Christ, whom they crucified but whom God raised from the dead.
- The Sanhedrin, seeing the boldness of Peter and John, were amazed, knowing they were unlearned men but had been with Jesus.
- The healed man stood with them, and since the miracle was undeniable, the leaders warned them not to speak in Jesus’ name again.
- Peter and John replied that they must obey God rather than men.
- They were threatened and released because of the support of the people who glorified God for the miracle.

Lessons from the Arrest of Peter and John:

- Christians should remain bold in the face of opposition.
- Miracles authenticate the power of Jesus Christ.
- Persecution is part of the Christian faith.
- God gives His servants courage to defend the truth.
- We must obey God rather than men.

ARREST AND MARTYRDOM OF STEPHEN (Acts 6:8–15, 7:1–60)

1. Stephen's Ministry (Acts 6:8–15):

- Stephen, one of the seven deacons, was full of faith, wisdom, and the Holy Spirit.
- He performed great wonders and signs among the people.
- Certain members of the synagogue argued with him but could not withstand his wisdom and the Spirit by which he spoke.
- They secretly instigated false witnesses to accuse him of speaking against Moses and the temple.
- He was seized and brought before the council.
- False witnesses claimed he said that Jesus would destroy the temple and change the customs of Moses.
- His face appeared like that of an angel as he stood before the council.

2. Stephen's Speech and Martyrdom (Acts 7:1–60):

- Stephen addressed the council, recounting the history of Israel from Abraham to Solomon.
- He accused the Jewish leaders of resisting the Holy Spirit, betraying, and murdering Jesus Christ, the Righteous One.
- The council was enraged and gnashed their teeth at him.
- Stephen, full of the Holy Spirit, looked up and saw the glory of God and Jesus standing at the right hand of God.
- He declared his vision, but the people cried out loudly, stopped their ears, and rushed at him.
- They dragged him out of the city and stoned him.
- Witnesses laid their garments at the feet of Saul (later Paul).

- Stephen prayed, “Lord Jesus, receive my spirit,” and “Lord, do not hold this sin against them.” Then he died, becoming the first Christian martyr.

Lessons from the Arrest and Martyrdom of Stephen:

- Christians should stand firm in faith even in the face of death.
- The Holy Spirit empowers believers with wisdom and boldness.
- False accusations may arise against true believers.
- Stephen’s forgiveness teaches Christians to love even their enemies.
- Persecution spreads the gospel, as seen later through Saul’s conversion.

EVALUATION

1. Narrate the healing of the lame man and explain why Peter and John were arrested.
2. How did Peter and John defend their faith before the council?
3. Who was Stephen and why was he arrested?
4. Explain Stephen’s message before the council.
5. What lessons can Christians learn from the martyrdom of Stephen?

ASSIGNMENT

1. Compare the persecution of Peter and John with that of Stephen.
2. Explain five lessons Christians today can learn from the arrest of Peter and John.
3. Discuss the significance of Stephen’s prayer of forgiveness at his death.

WEEK 10: PERSECUTION OF EARLY BELIEVERS (PART 2)

Acts 8:1–3; 9:1–2 – Saul's Persecution; Acts 12:1–4 – Martyrdom of James



INTRODUCTION

- The early Christians faced severe persecution after the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.
- This persecution arose because the Jewish leaders and Roman authorities saw the Christian faith as a threat to their traditions, power, and influence.
- In this lesson, we shall examine the persecution led by **Saul (later called Paul)** and the martyrdom of **James, the brother of John**.

SAUL'S PERSECUTION OF THE CHURCH (ACTS 8:1-3; 9:1-2)

- Saul, a Pharisee and strict defender of Jewish traditions, was one of the greatest persecutors of early believers.
- After the stoning of Stephen, Saul supported and supervised severe attacks on Christians.
- He went from house to house, dragging men and women to prison because of their faith in Jesus Christ.
- Saul obtained letters from the high priest to go to Damascus to arrest Christians and bring them back to Jerusalem for punishment.
- His actions scattered many believers to different regions such as Judea and Samaria, but the gospel continued to spread wherever they went.

MARTYRDOM OF JAMES (ACTS 12:1-4)

- King Herod Agrippa I also persecuted the Church to gain the favor of the Jews.
- He ordered the arrest of James, the brother of John (one of the sons of Zebedee and a close disciple of Jesus).
- James was executed by the sword, becoming the first of the twelve apostles to be martyred.
- Seeing that this pleased the Jews, Herod also arrested Peter and intended to kill him after the Passover.
- This showed how both political and religious leaders united in opposing the growth of Christianity.

EFFECTS OF THE PERSECUTION

- Persecution led to the **scattering of Christians**, which helped in the wider spread of the gospel beyond Jerusalem.
- It **tested the faith** of believers and made them more committed to Christ.
- Some Christians were imprisoned, while others were killed for their faith.
- The blood of the martyrs became a seed for the Church, encouraging others to hold firmly to their belief in Christ.
- Persecution brought the fulfillment of Jesus' prophecy that His disciples would suffer for His name's sake (John 16:33).

LESSONS FOR CHRISTIANS TODAY

- Christians should expect persecution for their faith in Christ.
- Persecution can be a tool that God uses to spread the gospel.
- Believers must remain courageous and faithful even in the face of suffering or death.
- Like James, Christians should be ready to sacrifice everything for Christ, including their lives.
- God can turn the greatest persecutors (like Saul) into great instruments for His work.

EVALUATION

1. Explain Saul's role in the persecution of the early Christians.
2. How did Saul obtain permission to persecute Christians in Damascus?
3. Narrate how James, the brother of John, was martyred.
4. State three effects of the persecution on the early Church.
5. Mention two lessons Christians today can learn from the persecution of the early Church.

ASSIGNMENT

1. Write a detailed account of Saul's persecution of the Christians before his conversion.
2. Compare the martyrdom of James with the persecution faced by modern Christians today.
3. Explain how persecution helped in the rapid spread of Christianity in the early Church.



JSS 3 CHRISTIAN RELIGIOUS STUDIES LESSON NOTES

SECOND TERM

Week	Topic	Content
1	The Ministry of Peter (Part 1)	Acts 8:4-25 – Peter and Simon the Magician.
2	The Ministry of Peter (Part 2)	Acts 9:32-42 – Healing miracles of Peter (Aeneas and Dorcas).
3	The Ministry of Peter (Part 3)	Acts 10:1-48 – Conversion of Cornelius. Acts 11:1-18 – Peter defends his action in Cornelius' house.
4	The Ministry of Peter (Part 4)	Acts 12:5-24 – Peter's release from prison and the death of Herod.
5	Midterm Examination	—
6	The Ministry of Apostle Paul (Part 1)	Acts 22:1-5, 26-30 – Paul's nativity and education; Acts 7:57-58; 8:1-3; 9:1-3 – Paul's persecution of the Church.
7	Midterm Break	—
8	The Ministry of Apostle Paul (Part 2)	Acts 9:1-19; 22:6-21 – The conversion of Paul; Acts 13–14 – Paul's first missionary journey.
9	The Ministry of Apostle Paul (Part 3)	Acts 15:1-35 – The Council at Jerusalem; Wrong and right ways of resolving conflicts.
10	Christian Unity and Living Among Non-Christians	Christian organisations in Nigeria; interdenominational cooperation; Christian giving (Phil. 4:14-20; 2 Cor. 8:3-5; 9:6-15); teachings that foster unity; Christians living in the community; Christian attitude to persecution.
11	Revision	All topics from Weeks 1–10.

12	Examination	—
13	Closing	—



WEEK 1: THE MINISTRY OF PETER (PART 1)

This lesson focuses on **Peter's ministry** as a leader of the early church and his encounter with **Simon the Magician**. Peter, one of Jesus' closest disciples, was empowered by the Holy Spirit to **preach the gospel, perform miracles, and uphold the integrity of the Christian faith**.

Understanding Peter's ministry helps students appreciate **faith, obedience, and the dangers of greed and deceit** in spiritual leadership.



PETER AND SIMON THE MAGICIAN (Acts 8:4-25):

- **Background:**

- After the death and resurrection of Jesus, the early Christians spread the gospel throughout Judea and Samaria.
- Many people, including **Simon the Magician**, were amazed by the miracles and teachings of the apostles.
- **Peter's Role:**
 - Peter, guided by the Holy Spirit, **preached the gospel, prayed for believers, and laid hands on new converts** so they could receive the Holy Spirit.
 - His ministry emphasized **faith in God, repentance, and obedience** rather than relying on magical powers or personal gain.
- **Simon's Mistake:**
 - Simon offered money to buy the power to confer the Holy Spirit on others, showing **greed and misunderstanding of spiritual gifts**.
 - Peter rebuked Simon, teaching that **spiritual gifts cannot be bought** and that repentance is necessary for forgiveness.

Key Points:

- The Holy Spirit is a **gift from God**, freely given to those who believe.
- True ministry is **based on faith, humility, and obedience**, not wealth or personal ambition.
- Leaders in the church must **serve with integrity and avoid corruption**.

LESSON APPLICATION:

- Students are encouraged to:
 - **Trust in God's power** rather than seeking shortcuts or worldly methods.
 - Recognize the importance of **faith, honesty, and humility** in serving God.
 - Avoid **greed, selfishness, and misuse of spiritual gifts** in personal or communal life.

- Understand that the **Holy Spirit empowers believers** to witness, preach, and serve effectively.
- This lesson also teaches that **God's work requires pure intentions and obedience**, not material gain or shortcuts.

EVALUATION:

1. Describe Peter's role in the early church according to Acts 8:4-25.
2. Who was Simon the Magician, and what mistake did he make?
3. Explain why spiritual gifts cannot be bought.
4. State three qualities that made Peter an effective minister of God.
5. How can students apply the lesson of Peter and Simon in their own lives?

ASSIGNMENT:

1. Write a short essay (200–250 words) on the ministry of Peter and the lessons it teaches about faith and obedience.
2. Prepare a diagram showing the encounter between Peter and Simon, highlighting Simon's mistake and Peter's teaching.
3. Discuss in two paragraphs how the story of Peter and Simon warns against greed and encourages integrity in leadership.

WEEK 2: THE MINISTRY OF PETER (PART 2)

Acts 9:32–42 – Healing Miracles of Peter (Aeneas And Dorcas)



INTRODUCTION

- After the coming of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost, Peter emerged as one of the most prominent apostles.
- His ministry was marked by **bold preaching, miracles, and leadership of the early Church.**
- In Acts 9:32–42, Peter performed two notable miracles: the healing of Aeneas and the raising of Dorcas (Tabitha).
- These miracles demonstrated the power of Jesus Christ working through His apostles, showing that God’s concern extended to both the sick and the needy.

THE HEALING OF AENEAS (ACTS 9:32–35)

- Peter traveled through various towns to strengthen and encourage believers.
- In **Lydda**, he met **Aeneas**, a man who had been **bedridden and paralyzed for eight years**.
- Peter said to him: *“Aeneas, Jesus Christ heals you; rise and make your bed.”*
- Immediately, Aeneas got up, completely healed.
- As a result, the entire residents of **Lydda and Sharon** saw what happened and **turned to the Lord**.

LESSONS FROM THE HEALING OF AENEAS

1. Jesus Christ is the true healer; Peter only acted as a vessel.
2. Miracles are a means of **evangelism**, bringing people to Christ.
3. Faith in the name of Jesus brings deliverance and restoration.
4. God cares for human suffering and restores the hopeless.

THE RAISING OF DORCAS/TABITHA (ACTS 9:36–42)

- In **Joppa**, there lived a disciple named **Dorcas** (also called Tabitha, meaning *gazelle*).
- Dorcas was known for her **good works and charitable deeds** – especially helping widows and the needy.
- She fell sick and died. The disciples washed her body and laid it in an upper room.
- Hearing that Peter was nearby in Lydda, they sent two men to urgently call him.
- When Peter arrived, widows stood around him, weeping and showing the clothes Dorcas had made for them.
- Peter sent everyone out, **knelt down and prayed**.
- He turned to the body and said: *“Tabitha, arise.”*

- She opened her eyes, sat up, and Peter gave her his hand and presented her alive to the believers.
- This miracle became known all over Joppa, and **many believed in the Lord**.

LESSONS FROM THE RAISING OF DORCAS

1. Good deeds and kindness leave lasting impact; Dorcas was remembered for her charity.
2. Prayer is essential in seeking God's intervention.
3. The power of God extends even over death.
4. The Church must care for the needy, widows, and vulnerable.
5. Miracles strengthen the faith of believers and attract non-believers to God.

GENERAL SIGNIFICANCE OF PETER'S MIRACLES

1. They confirmed Peter's authority and apostleship.
2. They showed that **Jesus Christ was still alive and working** through His disciples.
3. They revealed God's compassion for the sick, needy, and marginalized.
4. They led to the **growth of the early Church** as many turned to Christ.
5. They emphasize that true Christian ministry combines **preaching with acts of love and service**.

LESSONS FOR CHRISTIANS TODAY

- Christians should depend on the power of Jesus Christ in all situations.
- Believers should use their gifts and talents (like Dorcas) to serve others and glorify God.
- Prayer should always be the first response to challenges.
- Christians must be channels of healing, comfort, and encouragement to others.

- We must live so that even in death, our works will testify of our faith in God.

EVALUATION

1. Who was Aeneas, and how did Peter heal him?
2. Describe the character and good works of Dorcas before her death.
3. How did Peter raise Dorcas back to life?
4. State three results of Peter's miracles in Lydda and Joppa.
5. What lessons can Christians learn from the life of Dorcas?

ASSIGNMENT

1. Write short notes on the significance of Aeneas' healing.
2. Discuss the importance of Dorcas' charitable works to the growth of the early Church.
3. Mention five practical ways Christians today can emulate Dorcas in showing love to others.

WEEK 3: THE MINISTRY OF PETER (PART 3)

Acts 10:1–48 – Conversion of Cornelius; Acts 11:1–18 – Peter Defends His Action in Cornelius' House



INTRODUCTION

- The ministry of Peter played a vital role in the expansion of the early Church.
- Up until Acts 10, the gospel had been preached mainly to Jews and Jewish converts (proselytes).
- The conversion of **Cornelius**, a Gentile, marked a turning point in Christian history, showing that salvation was for all people, both Jews and Gentiles.

- This event also settled the question of whether Gentiles could be accepted without first becoming Jews.

CONVERSION OF CORNELIUS (ACTS 10:1–48)

- Cornelius was a Roman centurion (army officer) living in Caesarea.
- He was a devout and God-fearing man, who gave generously to the poor and prayed regularly to God.
- An angel of God appeared to him in a vision and instructed him to send for Peter in Joppa.
- At the same time, Peter had a vision of a sheet let down from heaven containing clean and unclean animals. He was told to “kill and eat.”
- Peter initially refused, saying he had never eaten anything unclean. But God told him not to call impure what He had made clean.
- This vision prepared Peter to understand that God shows no favoritism and that the gospel is for all nations.
- Peter obeyed the Spirit, went to Cornelius’ house, and preached Jesus Christ as Lord of all, who died and rose again for the salvation of mankind.
- While Peter was still speaking, the Holy Spirit came upon Cornelius and his household, and they began to speak in tongues and praise God.
- Peter then commanded that they be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ.

PETER DEFENDS HIS ACTION (ACTS 11:1–18)

- When Peter returned to Jerusalem, some Jewish believers (the circumcised group) criticized him for going into the house of Gentiles and eating with them.
- Peter explained the vision he had received from God and how the Holy Spirit fell upon Cornelius and his household just as it did upon the apostles at Pentecost.

- He reminded them of Jesus' promise that believers would be baptized with the Holy Spirit.
- He concluded that if God gave the same gift of the Spirit to Gentiles as He did to Jews, then they should not hinder God's plan.
- After hearing this, the Jewish believers had no objections and praised God, saying, "*So then, God has granted even to the Gentiles repentance unto life.*"

SIGNIFICANCE OF CORNELIUS' CONVERSION

- It marked the **official opening of the gospel to Gentiles**.
- It showed that God is no respecter of persons – salvation is for all who believe.
- It confirmed that the Holy Spirit is given to both Jews and Gentiles.
- It broke down the barrier between Jews and non-Jews in the Church.
- It fulfilled Jesus' command that the gospel should go to all nations (Matthew 28:19–20; Acts 1:8).

LESSONS FOR CHRISTIANS TODAY

- God shows no favoritism – all humans are equal before Him.
- Good works are important, but salvation comes only through faith in Jesus Christ.
- Christians should not discriminate based on race, tribe, or social class.
- The Holy Spirit is for everyone who believes in Christ.
- Christians must be obedient to God's call, even when it challenges tradition or personal beliefs.

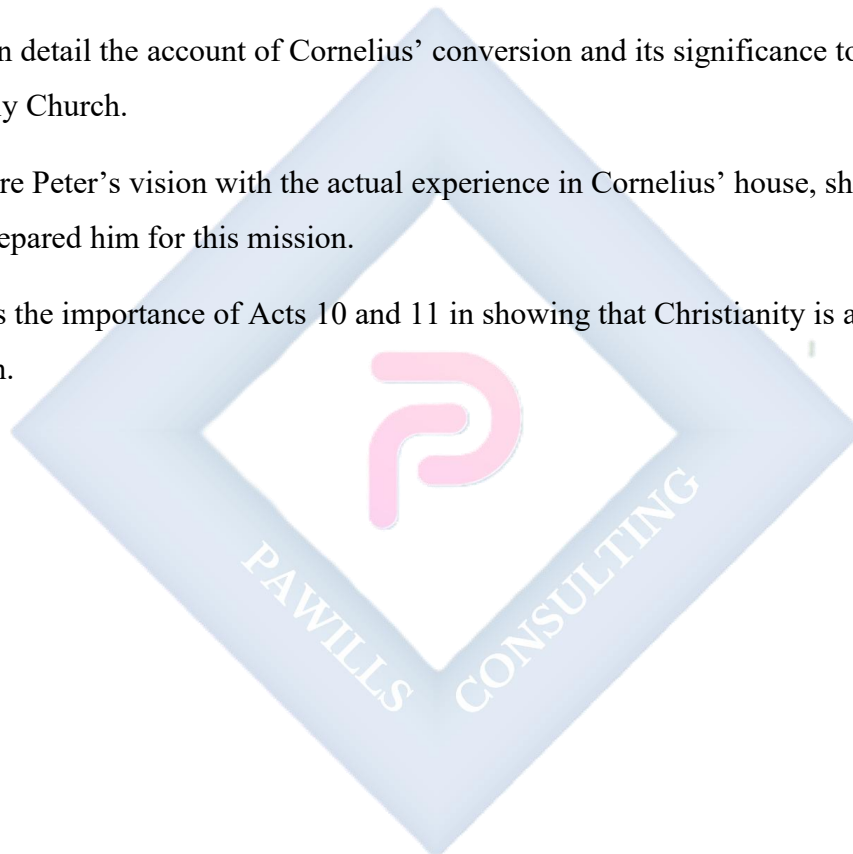
EVALUATION

1. Who was Cornelius and what qualities made him outstanding?

2. Explain Peter's vision of clean and unclean animals and its meaning.
3. How did the Holy Spirit confirm God's acceptance of Cornelius and his household?
4. Why did Peter defend his actions in Cornelius' house before the Jewish believers?
5. State three lessons modern Christians can learn from the conversion of Cornelius.

ASSIGNMENT

1. Write in detail the account of Cornelius' conversion and its significance to the growth of the early Church.
2. Compare Peter's vision with the actual experience in Cornelius' house, showing how God prepared him for this mission.
3. Discuss the importance of Acts 10 and 11 in showing that Christianity is a universal religion.



WEEK 4: THE MINISTRY OF PETER (PART 4)

Acts 12:5-24 – Peter's Release from Prison and the Death of Herod



INTRODUCTION TO PETER'S MINISTRY

- Peter was one of the **apostles of Jesus Christ** and a key leader in the early church.
- His ministry involved preaching, performing miracles, teaching new converts, and strengthening the faith of early Christians.
- Acts 12 highlights **God's intervention in Peter's release** and the consequences of opposing God's work through the story of Herod.

PETER'S ARREST AND THE CHURCH'S RESPONSE

- Herod Agrippa I imprisoned Peter to **please the Jewish leaders** and suppress the church.
- Acts 12:5: "So Peter was kept in prison, but the church was earnestly praying to God for him."
- **Significance of prayer:** Demonstrates the early church's dependence on God in times of crisis and the power of communal intercession.

DIVINE INTERVENTION AND PETER'S RELEASE

- Acts 12:6-11 describes an **angel of the Lord appearing** in Peter's prison.
 - Chains fell off Peter's hands.
 - The angel led him past guards and prison gates to freedom.
- Peter initially thought it was a vision but realized it was **God's miraculous deliverance**.
- **Lessons from Peter's release:**
 1. God protects and delivers His servants who are faithful.
 2. Prayer and faith are powerful tools in overcoming challenges.
 3. God's timing is perfect and beyond human control.

PETER'S MINISTRY AFTER RELEASE

- After his release, Peter went to the house of Mary, the mother of John Mark, where believers were praying.
- He encouraged and strengthened the early Christians, **continuing the work of evangelism**.
- Demonstrates that setbacks and persecution do not hinder God's plan.

THE DEATH OF HEROD

- Acts 12:20-23 describes Herod's pride and disobedience:
 - He accepted **praise as a god** rather than acknowledging God.
 - An angel of the Lord struck him down, and he died **because he did not give glory to God**.
- **Lessons from Herod's death:**
 1. Pride and arrogance against God lead to destruction.
 2. God's authority supersedes human power.
 3. Obedience and humility are essential for those in leadership.

IMPORTANCE OF THE LESSON

1. Encourages **faith and perseverance** in the face of persecution.
2. Demonstrates the **power of prayer** and communal support.
3. Teaches believers to **trust God for deliverance and protection**.
4. Highlights the **consequences of pride and disobedience** against God.
5. Strengthens understanding of **God's sovereignty and justice**.

EVALUATION

1. Describe the circumstances of Peter's arrest.
2. How did the early church respond to Peter's imprisonment?
3. Explain how Peter was miraculously delivered from prison.
4. What led to the death of Herod according to Acts 12?
5. Mention two lessons Christians can learn from Peter's release.

ASSIGNMENT

1. Write a short essay: “The Role of Prayer in Peter’s Deliverance.”
2. Identify three ways God’s intervention is shown in Acts 12 and explain their significance.
3. Discuss how modern Christians can apply the lessons from Herod’s death in daily life.



WEEK 6: THE MINISTRY OF APOSTLE PAUL (PART 1)

Acts 22:1–5, 26–30 – Paul’s Nativity and Education; Acts 7:57–58; 8:1–3; 9:1–3 – Paul’s Persecution of the Church



PAUL’S NATIVITY AND EDUCATION (ACTS 22:1–5, 26–30)

Paul, originally known as **Saul**, was born in **Tarsus**, a prominent city in **Cilicia**. This gave him the privilege of being a **Roman citizen by birth**, which later played a very important role in his ministry and legal protection.

Saul was a **Jew by race**, belonging to the tribe of **Benjamin**. From childhood, he was trained strictly in Jewish customs and religion. He was sent to Jerusalem, where he studied under

Gamaliel, a famous teacher of the Law. Under Gamaliel, Saul became well-versed in the Law of Moses and traditions of the fathers.

Because of his strict upbringing, Saul grew into a zealous Pharisee, passionate for the Jewish faith and determined to defend it against anything he considered a threat.

When Paul was arrested later in his ministry, he reminded the authorities of his background: his Jewish identity, his Roman citizenship, and his education under Gamaliel. These qualifications gave him respect both among Jews and Romans, and also helped in spreading the gospel across both Jewish and Gentile communities.

Lessons from Paul's nativity and education:

1. God can use our background and training for His purpose.
2. A good education prepares one for future responsibilities.
3. Religious zeal without true knowledge can lead to wrong actions.
4. Roman citizenship helped Paul in his mission, showing that every privilege can serve God's work.

PAUL'S PERSECUTION OF THE CHURCH (ACTS 7:57–58; 8:1–3; 9:1–3)

Saul's zeal as a Pharisee made him a fierce persecutor of the early Christians.

In **Acts 7:57–58**, Saul was present at the stoning of **Stephen**, the first Christian martyr. Though he did not throw stones himself, he kept the garments of those who killed Stephen, showing his support for the act.

In **Acts 8:1–3**, Saul actively persecuted the church. He went from house to house, dragging men and women out and putting them in prison. His mission was to destroy the followers of Christ and wipe out Christianity from Jerusalem.

In **Acts 9:1–3**, Saul went further, requesting letters from the High Priest to the synagogues in Damascus so that he could arrest any followers of "the Way" (Christians) and bring them bound

to Jerusalem. It was on this journey that he later encountered the risen Christ and his life was transformed.

Lessons from Paul's persecution of the Church:

1. Zeal without knowledge leads to violence and error.
2. Persecution of Christians cannot stop God's work.
3. God can transform even the worst persecutor into a great servant.
4. Christians must be prepared to endure persecution for their faith.
5. God's grace is greater than man's sins.

SUMMARY

- Paul (Saul) was a Jew from Tarsus, a Roman citizen, and educated under Gamaliel in Jewish law (Acts 22:1–5, 26–30).
- His background made him a zealous Pharisee, but he initially used this zeal to persecute the church.
- He approved of Stephen's stoning and arrested Christians, attempting to destroy the church (Acts 7:57–58; 8:1–3).
- On his way to Damascus to arrest more Christians (Acts 9:1–3), his encounter with Christ began his transformation.
- His life shows that God can change anyone and use their background for His glory.

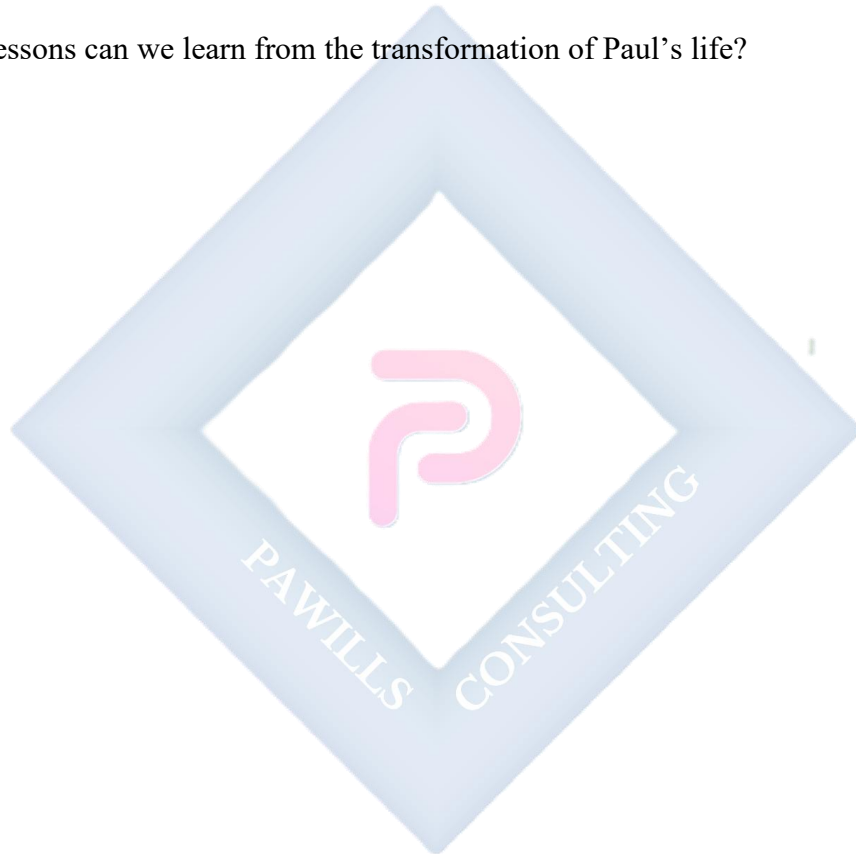
EVALUATION

1. Describe Paul's nativity and background as found in Acts 22:1–5.
2. Who was Gamaliel, and what role did he play in Paul's education?
3. How did Paul persecute the early church according to Acts 8:1–3?

4. Explain Paul's involvement in the stoning of Stephen.
5. What lesson can Christians learn from Paul's early life and actions?

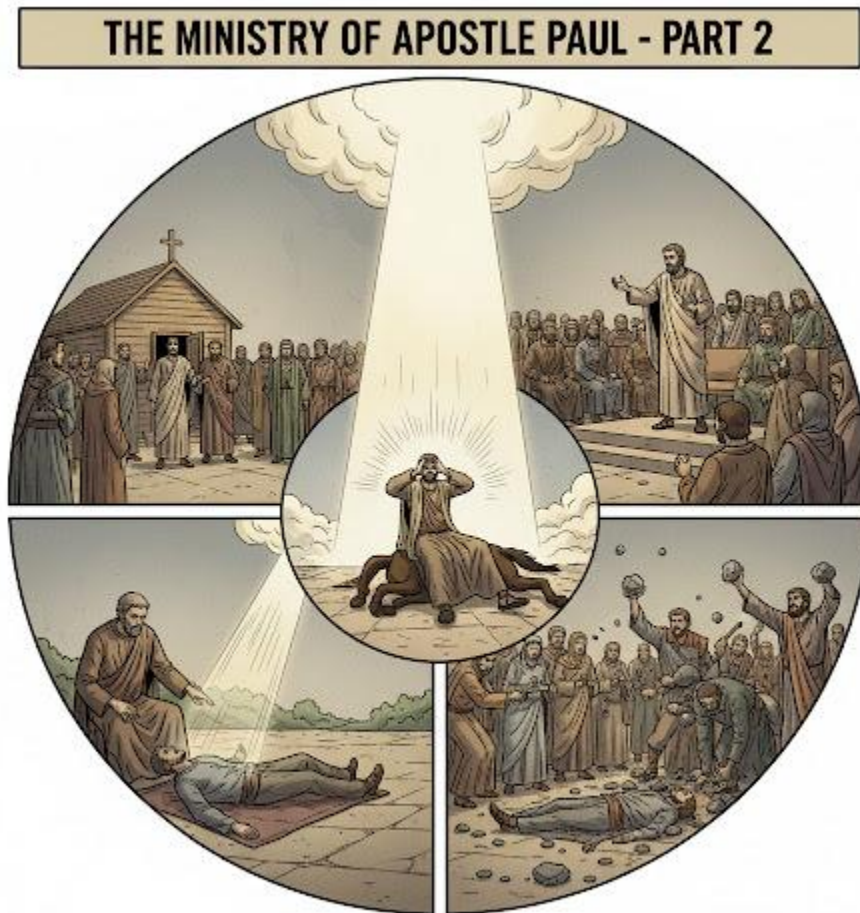
ASSIGNMENT

1. Write a short biography of Saul before his conversion.
2. Mention three ways Saul persecuted the early church and explain them briefly.
3. What lessons can we learn from the transformation of Paul's life?



WEEK 8: THE MINISTRY OF APOSTLE PAUL (PART 2)

The ministry of Apostle Paul is central to the **spread of Christianity in the first century**. This lesson focuses on **Paul's conversion and his first missionary journey**, highlighting his transformation, dedication, and the impact of his missionary work.



THE CONVERSION OF PAUL:

- **Scriptural References:** Acts 9:1-19; 22:6-21
- Saul of Tarsus, later called Paul, was originally a **persecutor of Christians**, seeking to destroy the church.

- On his way to Damascus, a **light from heaven flashed around him**, and he fell to the ground.
- He heard the voice of Jesus asking, “Saul, Saul, why do you persecute me?”
- Saul asked who was speaking, and Jesus revealed Himself.
- Following this, Saul was **blind for three days**, reflecting his spiritual and physical transformation.
- **Ananias**, a disciple of Jesus, was instructed to visit Saul, lay hands on him, and restore his sight.
- Saul was baptized, filled with the Holy Spirit, and began preaching about Jesus, becoming **one of Christianity’s greatest apostles**.

Lessons from Paul’s Conversion:

- God can **transform even the most unlikely individuals** for His purposes.
- Conversion involves **repentance, obedience, and commitment**.
- God calls individuals to **serve His mission** despite past mistakes.

PAUL’S FIRST MISSIONARY JOURNEY:

- **Scriptural Reference:** Acts 13–14
- Paul, along with Barnabas, was **sent by the Holy Spirit** from Antioch to preach the Gospel to Gentiles.
- They visited key cities including **Seleucia, Cyprus, Pisidian Antioch, Iconium, Lystra, and Derbe**.
- Activities during the journey:
 - Preaching in synagogues and public places
 - Performing miracles, healing the sick, and casting out evil spirits

- Converting both Jews and Gentiles to Christianity
- Establishing churches and appointing elders to lead them
- Facing opposition, persecution, and rejection, yet remaining steadfast in faith

Importance of Paul's First Missionary Journey:

- **Spread of Christianity:** Introduced the Gospel to Gentile regions outside Israel.
- **Strengthening the Church:** Established local leadership and nurtured new believers.
- **Demonstration of Courage and Faith:** Showed commitment to God's mission despite hardships.
- **Promotion of Unity:** Encouraged believers to remain faithful amidst persecution.

EVALUATION:

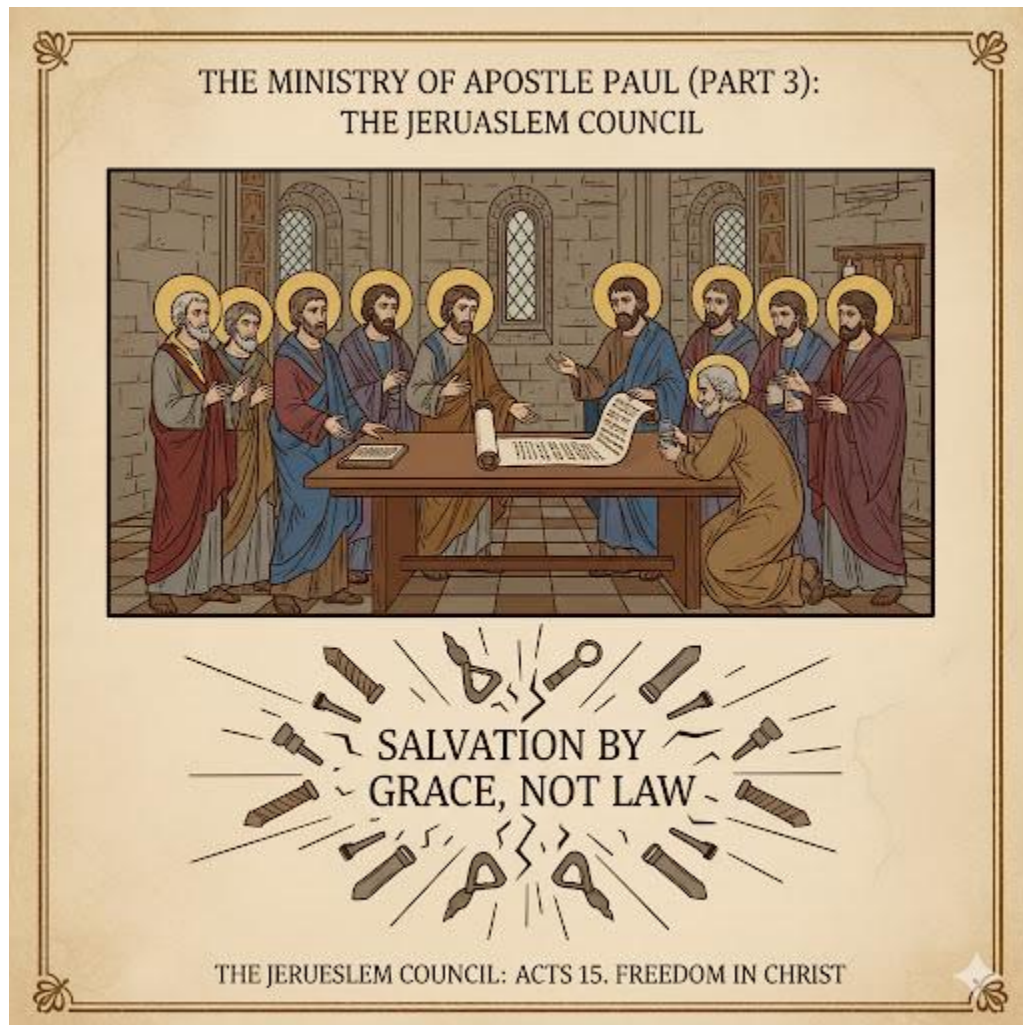
1. Describe the events of Paul's conversion according to Acts 9:1-19.
2. List the cities visited during Paul's first missionary journey.
3. Explain the importance of Paul's first missionary journey to the spread of Christianity.
4. Identify three lessons Christians can learn from Paul's conversion and ministry.

ASSIGNMENT:

1. Write an essay (200–250 words) on the significance of Paul's conversion in the history of the church.
2. Prepare a map showing **Paul's first missionary journey**, indicating all major cities visited.
3. Role-play a scenario where Paul and Barnabas face opposition in a city and explain how they responded according to Acts 13–14.

WEEK 9: THE MINISTRY OF APOSTLE PAUL (PART 3)

Acts 15:1–35 – The Council at Jerusalem; Wrong and Right Ways of Resolving Conflicts



THE COUNCIL AT JERUSALEM (Acts 15:1–35)

1. The Dispute:

- Some men from Judea came down to Antioch teaching the brethren that unless they were circumcised according to the custom of Moses, they could not be saved.
- This teaching caused confusion and disagreement among the believers.
- Paul and Barnabas strongly opposed this view, leading to sharp disputes.

- The church at Antioch decided to send Paul, Barnabas, and some others to Jerusalem to consult the apostles and elders concerning the matter.

2. The Meeting at Jerusalem:

- The apostles and elders gathered to discuss the issue.
- There was much debate, but Peter stood up and reminded them that God had chosen him to preach to the Gentiles, and God gave them the Holy Spirit just as He gave the Jews.
- He stressed that salvation comes through the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and not through the law of Moses or circumcision.
- Paul and Barnabas also testified of the miracles and wonders God had done among the Gentiles through them.
- James, the leader of the Jerusalem church, gave the final judgment: Gentiles should not be burdened with the full law of Moses but should abstain from things polluted by idols, fornication, eating strangled animals, and blood.

3. The Decision and Its Outcome:

- A letter was drafted and sent with Paul, Barnabas, Judas (called Barsabbas), and Silas to the Gentile churches.
- The letter encouraged the Gentiles and freed them from unnecessary burdens.
- The believers at Antioch rejoiced when they received the message.
- This decision united the church and resolved the conflict peacefully.

WRONG WAYS OF RESOLVING CONFLICTS

- Resorting to violence, fighting, or quarrelling.
- Spreading rumours or gossiping about the issue.
- Insulting, mocking, or abusing others.

- Taking laws into one's own hands instead of following due process.
- Being rigid and refusing to listen to other people's opinions.
- Keeping malice or withdrawing from fellowship.
- Using force, intimidation, or threats.

RIGHT WAYS OF RESOLVING CONFLICTS

- **Dialogue and discussion:** Listening to all sides before making a decision.
- **Consulting elders and leaders:** Seeking advice from wise and experienced people, just as the apostles and elders did in Jerusalem.
- **Prayer and guidance of the Holy Spirit:** Asking God for wisdom to know the right step.
- **Patience and tolerance:** Being calm and willing to understand other people's viewpoints.
- **Compromise where necessary:** Agreeing on what is fair and just for everyone.
- **Love and forgiveness:** Approaching issues with humility and readiness to forgive.
- **Use of written agreements or official letters:** As seen in the council's letter to the Gentiles.

LESSONS FROM THE COUNCIL AT JERUSALEM

- Disputes and conflicts are natural in the church and society, but they should be resolved peacefully.
- Leadership and guidance are necessary in handling sensitive matters.
- Salvation is by faith in Jesus Christ, not by observing human traditions or laws.
- Collective decision-making helps to promote unity in the church.
- Conflicts, if properly resolved, can strengthen the bond among believers.

EVALUATION

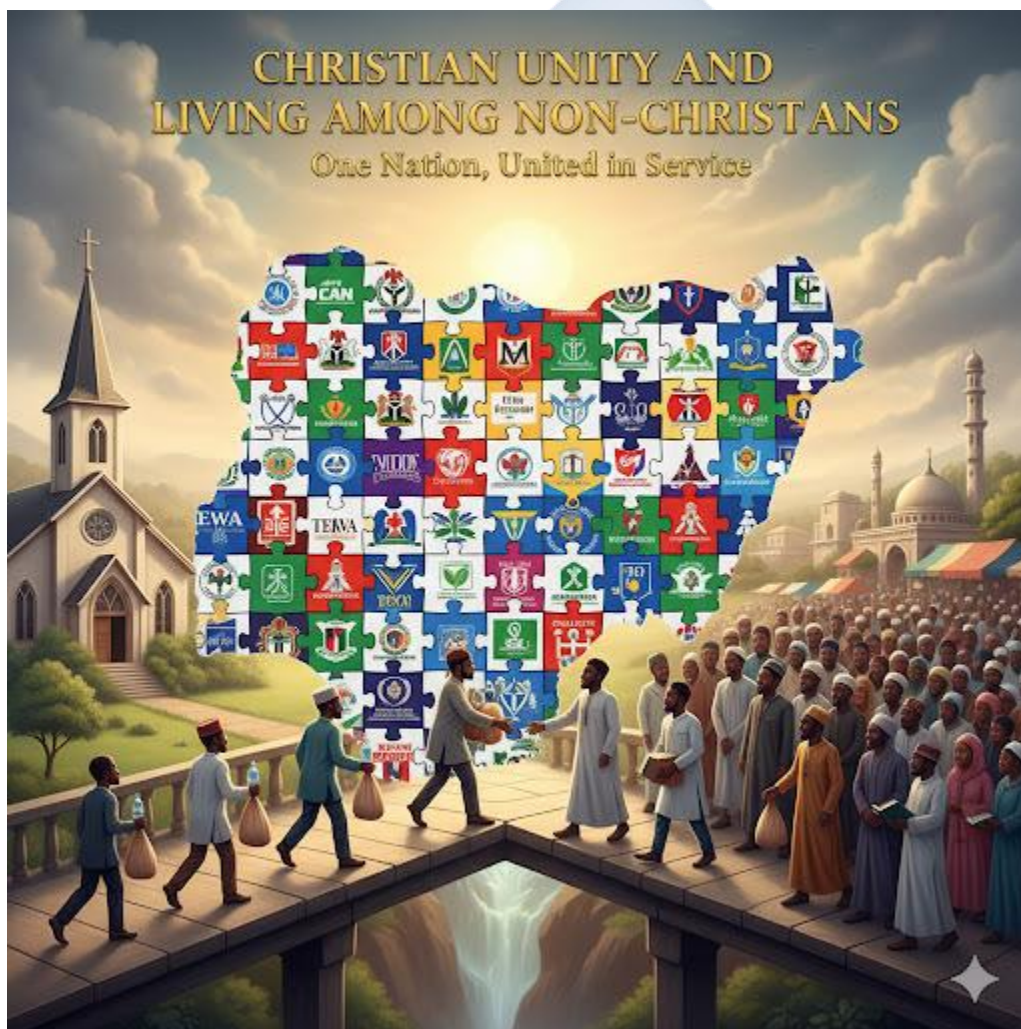
1. Why was the Council at Jerusalem called?
2. What was the resolution of the council?
3. Mention three wrong ways of resolving conflicts.
4. State four right ways of resolving conflicts.
5. What lessons can we learn from the Council at Jerusalem?

ASSIGNMENT

1. Narrate the events that led to the Council at Jerusalem and its outcome.
2. Explain five wrong ways people attempt to resolve conflicts in society today.
3. Suggest five Christian ways of resolving disputes in the family, church, or community.

WEEK 10: CHRISTIAN UNITY AND LIVING AMONG NON-CHRISTIANS

- *Christian organisations in Nigeria*
- *Interdenominational cooperation*
- *Christian giving (Phil. 4:14–20; 2 Cor. 8:3–5; 9:6–15)*
- *Teachings that foster unity*
- *Christians living in the community*
- *Christian attitude to persecution*



INTRODUCTION

- The prayer of Jesus in John 17:21 was that all His followers may be **one** just as He and the Father are one.
- Christian unity means **oneness of purpose, faith, and love among Christians** regardless of denomination, tribe, or background.
- In Nigeria, Christians belong to different denominations but are called to work together for the advancement of the gospel and the good of society.
- Unity among Christians enables them to live peacefully with one another and with non-Christians, even in times of opposition and persecution.

CHRISTIAN ORGANISATIONS IN NIGERIA

Several Christian bodies exist in Nigeria to promote unity, defend the faith, and provide social services. Examples include:

- **Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN)** – the umbrella body of Christians in Nigeria.
- **Pentecostal Fellowship of Nigeria (PFN)** – a body of Pentecostal churches promoting unity and evangelism.
- **Scripture Union (SU)** – focuses on Bible study, evangelism, and discipling students.
- **Christian Council of Nigeria (CCN)** – promotes ecumenical cooperation and social responsibility.
- **Catholic Bishops Conference of Nigeria (CBCN)** – coordinates Catholic leadership in Nigeria.
- **Fellowship of Christian Students (FCS), Nigerian Fellowship of Evangelical Students (NIFES),** and other student/youth fellowships.

FUNCTIONS OF CHRISTIAN ORGANISATIONS

1. Promote unity among Christians.
2. Preach the gospel and defend the faith.

3. Provide education, health, and humanitarian services.
4. Speak with one voice on national issues.
5. Encourage Christians to live peacefully among non-Christians.

INTERDENOMINATIONAL COOPERATION

- Refers to **collaboration between different Christian denominations** (Catholic, Anglican, Baptist, Methodist, Pentecostal, etc.) for common goals.
- Areas of cooperation:
 1. Joint evangelism and missionary activities.
 2. Ecumenical services and prayer meetings.
 3. Establishment of schools, hospitals, and charities.
 4. Speaking out on social, political, and moral issues.
 5. Providing relief materials during crises.
- Benefits: reduces division, fosters love, presents a united front to the world, and strengthens the witness of the Church.

CHRISTIAN GIVING (PHIL. 4:14–20; 2 COR. 8:3–5; 9:6–15)

Key Teachings:

- Giving should be **voluntary, cheerful, and sacrificial**.
- Christians should support ministers of the gospel and those in need.
- God rewards cheerful givers with spiritual and material blessings.
- Giving demonstrates love, unity, and obedience to God.
- Paul commended the Philippians for supporting him financially (Phil. 4:14–20).

- The Macedonian Christians gave **beyond their ability** to support others (2 Cor. 8:3–5).
- Giving is compared to **sowing seed** – the more one sows, the more one reaps (2 Cor. 9:6–15).

TEACHINGS THAT FOSTER UNITY

- Love one another (John 13:34–35).
- Forgive and reconcile with one another (Matt. 18:21–22).
- Bear one another's burdens (Gal. 6:2).
- Avoid divisions and unnecessary disputes (1 Cor. 1:10–13).
- Recognise that all believers are members of **one body in Christ** (Rom. 12:4–5).
- Work together in humility and peace (Eph. 4:1–6).

CHRISTIANS LIVING IN THE COMMUNITY

- Christians should be examples of good citizenship and moral behaviour.
- Show love and tolerance towards non-Christians.
- Contribute positively to community development.
- Promote peace, justice, and fairness in all dealings.
- Avoid discrimination, tribalism, and hatred.
- Live in such a way that non-Christians will glorify God.

CHRISTIAN ATTITUDE TO PERSECUTION

- Persecution means hostility, suffering, or unfair treatment because of one's faith.

- Jesus taught that His followers will face persecution but should rejoice because their reward is great in heaven (Matt. 5:10–12).
- Attitudes expected of Christians:
 1. Endure persecution with faith and patience.
 2. Do not retaliate with evil (Rom. 12:17–21).
 3. Pray for those who persecute you (Matt. 5:44).
 4. Remain steadfast in faith even in trials.
 5. Take comfort that persecution strengthens the Church.

EVALUATION

1. Define Christian unity and explain why it is important.
2. Mention five Christian organisations in Nigeria and state one function of each.
3. What is interdenominational cooperation? Give two benefits.
4. Summarise Paul's teaching on Christian giving in 2 Cor. 9:6–15.
5. State four teachings of the Bible that promote unity among Christians.
6. How should Christians live in their community among non-Christians?
7. What attitude should Christians show in times of persecution?

ASSIGNMENT

1. List and explain five ways interdenominational cooperation strengthens the Church in Nigeria.
2. Using Philippians 4:14–20, discuss how Christians today can support the work of ministers and missionaries.

3. Write an essay on **“Christian unity as a tool for national development in Nigeria.”**

